

The Serial Forgetting: Coherence, Decay, and the Universal Cascade

How Complex Systems Collapse from the Inside — and Why the Sky Is Silent

Version 1.1 — July 2026

Author's Note

This essay began as a conversation — a session of thinking out loud about a frustrating social pattern many of us have encountered: the person who wants what others have, refuses to accept any cost, collides with reality, and then rewrites the story to make themselves the victim. From that small seed, the pattern appeared again in history, ecology, philosophy, and the silence of the stars.

This is not a scientific paper. It does not offer mathematical proofs or controlled experiments. It is an **examination of a correlation** that appears across disciplines — a lens for seeing familiar things in a new way. If you find yourself thinking “that’s like something else I’ve noticed,” the essay is working as intended. The goal is not to prove a law of nature. It is to help you see a pattern that, once noticed, is difficult to unsee.

On the inevitable objection — “correlation is not causation”:

This phrase is true and also irrelevant here. The essay does not claim to have *proven* a causal mechanism across all domains. It claims that the same pattern recurs often enough — in quantum physics, ecology, history, philosophy, and personal life — that ignoring it is more costly than explaining it.

When seven independent philosophical traditions, three civilizational cycle models, the mathematics of quantum decoherence, the ecological fossil record, and the arc of personal relationships all trace the same shape, the correlation itself demands attention. You can call it a coincidence, a cognitive bias, or a universal mechanism. The essay’s argument is that the first two explanations are harder to defend than the third.

Correlation is not proof. But correlation across this many independent domains is *information*. The essay is an offer to consider that information, not a demand to accept a law.

A glossary of scientific terms and foreign words used in this essay can be found in section 8 for reference.

Abstract

All complex systems — quantum states, ecosystems, civilizations, marriages, scientific paradigms — follow a single arc. They begin in a state of coherence where parts align naturally, energy flows efficiently, and the system remembers its own structure. This coherence requires no enforcement because it is the system's default state. Over time, that remembering becomes automatic, then unconscious, then forgotten entirely. The forgetting manifests as a predictable four-stage cascade: comparison, territoriality, collision, and narrative rewriting. This cascade recurs across every domain examined in this essay with sufficient regularity to suggest it is not metaphor but mechanism — a consequence of how any complex system behaves when the energy that maintains its coherence stops flowing. The universality of the pattern offers explanations for the silence of the cosmos, the shape of human history, the arc of personal relationships, and the current planetary climate crisis.

1. Introduction: An Observation, Then a Pattern

It starts with a person in a store. You know the type — something between a demand and an assumption. She wants the manager. The rules don't apply to her. Someone else got something she didn't, and that's intolerable. She is experiencing a specific kind of suffering: the gap between what she believes she is owed and what reality is providing.

This person — colloquially the “Karen” — is easy to mock. But mockery misses the point. She is not a unique character flaw. She is a **pure expression of a cascade** that operates at every scale of human organization. The same engine that drives her behavior drives the collapse of startups, the fall of empires, and — if we are not careful — the silence of the cosmos.

The engine has four stages, captured in four acronyms that everyone already knows: FOMO, NIMBY, FAFO, and HILO. Each connects to the next the way a falling row of dominoes connects to the one after it.

- **Fear Of Missing Out (FOMO)** — the engine of comparison, status anxiety, and desire for what others have
- **Not In My Back Yard (NIMBY)** — the constraint that demands benefits without accepting costs
- **Fuck Around, Find Out (FAFO)** — the unavoidable collision when unrealistic expectations meet reality
- **History Is the Loudest Opinion (HILO)** — the rewriting of the record after the fact by those who shouted longest

These four were initially understood as social phenomena — descriptions of a particular kind of difficult person. But examination revealed they are not merely individual character flaws. They are *stages in a cascade* that recurs at every scale of complex organization.

What follows is a survey of that cascade across all available domains: the quantum substrate, biological evolution, ecological succession, human societies, philosophical traditions, scientific revolutions, and the probable fate of technological civilizations. The pattern is sufficiently consistent to warrant a hypothesis: this cascade is not a collection of analogies but a single process operating at different scales — the expression of entropy in systems whose coherence is no longer actively maintained.

1.5 The Core Insight: One Path and Its Forgetting

Before going further, the central idea needs to be stated plainly, because it will appear in every section that follows.

There is only **one natural state** — the **Second Path**. It is what any system looks like when it is functioning as it should: parts aligned, energy flowing, no friction, no comparison, no territoriality, no distorted memory. It is not a moral achievement. It is the default.

The First Path is not a different path. It is not the opposite of the Second Path. It is the Second Path, forgotten.

Drop a rock. It falls. Gravity is not the “opposite” of holding the rock in your hand. It is what happens when you stop holding. The **First Path** is gravity on systems that have stopped maintaining their coherence.

This is critical because this entire essay hangs on it. If you read “**Second Path**” and think “that sounds like the good side of a duality,” you will misunderstand. There is no duality. There is one path and its decay. Darkness is not the opposite of light. It is light’s absence. The **First Path** is the absence that follows forgetting.

Not every system follows this arc exactly — but enough do, across enough independent domains, that the shape is worth examining. The language of “all” and “every” in the sections that follow is emphasis, not insistence. The reader is invited to test each claim against their own experience.

The acronyms (FOMO, NIMBY, FAFO, HILO) are the stages of that forgetting.

2. The Universal Arc

Everything starts on the **Second Path**. That’s the default. But the default is not a fixed state — it requires continuous, unnoticed maintenance. The following describes what happens when that maintenance falters. It is not a cycle of opposites. It is a single trajectory: starting on the path, then leaving it.

The Starting Point — Second Path (Coherence)

The system is in its natural state. Parts align without friction. Energy flows efficiently. The system “knows” what it is without having to think about it. No comparison with other systems occurs because the system is complete in itself. No territoriality is needed because nothing threatens the boundary. No collision is awaited because the system is within its operating parameters. The narrative is identical to the truth because there is no gap between what happened and what is remembered.

This is not “good” in a moral sense. It is simply the default — what happens when a system forms correctly and has not yet begun to degrade.

Departure

Coherence requires continuous, invisible maintenance. In the quantum domain, this means isolation from environmental entanglement. In biology, it means homeostasis. In societies, it means the active practice of shared values. The maintenance is never noticed when it is happening — it is simply the background hum of the system working correctly.

But maintenance requires energy. When that energy wavers — because the system is large, old, distracted, or complacent — the coherence begins to leak. The parts of the system begin to experience themselves as separate. Comparison becomes possible for the first time.

The Cascade

Once separation is felt, the four-stage cascade proceeds in order. Each stage makes the next inevitable. There is nothing else pushing the system — no external force, no opposing principle. The cascade is what happens when a system that used to know itself forgets what it is.

1. **Comparison (FOMO).** Parts of the system notice other parts. Some have more, are larger, seem happier. The desire to be what one is not — the root of suffering in every major philosophical tradition — appears. This is not yet destructive, but it opens the door.
2. **Territoriality (NIMBY).** Comparison creates insecurity. Insecurity demands boundaries. “What I have is mine, and you cannot have it.” Benefits are demanded; costs are refused. The system begins to fight itself.
3. **Collision (FAFO).** A system fighting itself cannot stand. The contradictions accumulate until something breaks. The collision is not punishment for bad behavior — it is the logical consequence of accumulated internal tension. It was always going to happen. The only question was when.
4. **Narrative Rewriting (HILO).** After the collision, survivors rewrite what happened. The complexity of the original coherence is reduced to a simple story. The losers are blamed. The winners are justified. The actual texture of what was lost becomes inaccessible. The next generation inherits the narrative, not the reality.

Aftermath — Reset or Dissolution

The system either finds a new coherence at a different level of organization, or it dissipates entirely. If it finds coherence again, it begins again from the **Second Path** — but never the same way twice, because the substrate has changed. If it dissolves, the components scatter and may form new systems elsewhere.

This is not a circle. It is a spiral that, without intervention, trends toward simpler, louder, more brittle configurations over time.

3. Evidence from All Scales

3.1 The Quantum Substrate

The quantum domain is the purest example of the pattern because it operates without interpretation. An electron in a coherent superposition has no envy of other states, no territoriality about its orbital, no need to touch the nucleus to know its repulsion, and no capacity to rewrite the measurement record. It simply *is* what it is.

But the moment a quantum system interacts with its environment — the moment it “forgets” its isolation — decoherence begins. The superposition collapses. The coherent state becomes a classical state. The rich information of the quantum wavefunction leaks into the environment as heat. The system becomes mundane because it forgot to stay isolated.

The mechanism is the same: the **Second Path** (coherent superposition) is the natural default. It requires no enforcement. But it does require *not being disturbed*. The **First Path** (decohered classical state) is what happens when the system is disturbed and cannot maintain its integrity.

There is no dualism here. No male/female, no yin/yang, no opposing forces that must be balanced. There is simply a coherent state and its inevitable decay when maintenance stops.

3.2 Ecology and Evolution

The evolutionary record shows the same pattern. A new ecosystem reaches climax state: every niche filled, energy cycling efficiently, balance achieved. This is the **Second Path** — the system at its most coherent.

Then specialization begins. Species optimize for their particular niche. They grow larger, more specialized, more dependent on specific conditions. They compete. They guard territory (NIMBY). The system becomes brittle — incredibly efficient within its range, but unable to absorb shocks outside it.

When the shock comes — and it always does — the brittle system shatters. The large specialized species go extinct first. The generalists — the small, the adaptable, the ones that never fully specialized — survive. The collapse is attributed to the external shock (the asteroid, the volcano), but the real

cause is the forgetting that happened over millions of years before: the slow drift from resilience to optimization. The asteroid was punctuation; the forgetting was the sentence.

The Permian-Triassic extinction event illustrates the same pattern. The trigger was the Siberian Traps volcanism. But the mechanism was a runaway greenhouse feedback loop that the system had been pushing itself toward for millions of years.

The Classic Maya collapse is the same process compressed into centuries instead of millions of years. By the 9th century AD, the Maya had one of the highest population densities in the ancient world. To feed everyone, they cleared nearly all their forests. Satellite data and pollen records show that by 950 AD, the Maya lowlands were essentially treeless. Forests regulate rainfall, hold soil, and maintain the moisture cycle that keeps a region habitable. By removing them, the Maya changed their own climate — paleoclimate records from lake sediments and cave deposits confirm that the 9th to 11th centuries brought the worst multi-decadal droughts in Maya prehistory. The Maya had survived droughts before through irrigation, reservoirs, and agricultural flexibility. But after centuries of deforestation, they had removed their own resilience. They had optimized so hard for growth that they eliminated their margin for error. When the drought came, there was nothing left to buffer it. The external trigger (drought) gets the blame, but the real cause was the slow forgetting that turned a resilient system into a brittle one.

3.3 Human Societies

The Roman Republic lasted nearly 500 years — one of the longest-running functional systems in Western history. Its founding was built on *mos maiorum*, the way of the ancestors — unwritten norms of civic virtue, service before self, honor in competition. Senators competed by building aqueducts, not fortunes. This was the **Second Path**.

The cascade:

- **FOMO:** Generals serving abroad saw provincial governors accumulating wealth without battlefield risk. They wanted their share. Marius professionalized the army and promised land to soldiers — not because it was good for Rome, but because the soldiers' loyalty now belonged to the general who paid them, not to the Republic.
- **NIMBY:** The patrician class responded by entrenching. They bought up the land of small farmers displaced by war. The farmers flooded Rome, became a restless urban mob. Everyone wanted the benefits of empire; nobody wanted to pay for the army that won it.
- **FAFO:** Marius vs. Sulla. Caesar vs. Pompey. Octavian vs. Antony. A hundred years of civil war. The Republic died not from barbarian invasion but from Romans killing Romans because the system had lost its internal coherence and could not peacefully resolve disputes anymore.

- **HILO:** Augustus called it “restoring the Republic.” It was a monarchy. Everyone knew it. But the name stuck, and within two generations, nobody remembered what a real republic felt like. The history was written by the loudest — and the loudest was the emperor.

3.4 Civilizational Cycles

The Hindu Yuga cycle describes exactly this cascade at the largest temporal scale:

- **Satya Yuga:** Truth reigns. Humans are content, meditative, peaceful. No disease, no conflict, no envy. Duration: 1,728,000 years. The **Second Path**.
- **Treta Yuga:** Vice appears but virtue dominates. Sacrifice and ritual replace direct knowing. FOMO begins — the desire for what others have enters human experience. Duration: 1,296,000 years.
- **Dvapara Yuga:** Disease, war, and disaster. Knowledge declines. Pursuit of pleasure dominates. NIMBY at civilizational scale — hoarding, territoriality, inequality. Duration: 864,000 years.
- **Kali Yuga:** Greed, short lives, truth hidden. The age of quarrel. The loudest drown out the wisest. Nobody remembers what was lost because nobody lived in the age that had it. Full HILO. Duration: 432,000 years.

The Andean concept of *Pachakuti* describes the same arc in different terms: a world-age of order and coherence, followed by gradual decline, ended by a violent overturning (the *pachakuti* itself), then a reset. The Incas identified five such ages. Each ended not because of external invasion but because the internal balance was exhausted.

These traditions emerged on different continents, in different millennia, with no contact between them. They all describe the same pattern. This is either a remarkable coincidence or evidence that the pattern is built into the structure of human societies.

A quantitative version of the same insight comes from Peter Turchin’s cliodynamics — the mathematical modeling of historical data. Analyzing cycles across Rome, medieval France, ancient China, and the United States, Turchin identified consistent 200-300 year secular cycles of stability and integration followed by crisis and disintegration, with nested 50-year instability cycles. His models predict these surges are driven by *elite overproduction*: when a society matures, the number of educated aspirants outgrows the number of prestigious positions. The excess elites stop cooperating, recruit followers from the frustrated majority, and destabilize the system from within. In a 2012 paper in the *Journal of Peace Research*, Turchin used this model to predict that the next peak of American political instability would arrive around 2020 — a prediction made eight years early. The mechanism is FOMO and NIMBY at the structural level: too many

qualified people competing for too few slots, the system becoming top-heavy with aspirants who cannot find a place, and the resulting fragmentation accelerating the cascade.

3.5 Philosophy: The Universal Diagnosis

Every major philosophical tradition independently diagnosed the same disease and prescribed the same cure.

Buddha (600 BCE, India) identified *tanha* — craving, thirst, the desire for things to be other than they are — as the root of all suffering. That is FOMO translated into the language of the spirit. The Eightfold Path is a structured practice of returning to the **Second Path**: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. Nirvana is not a reward for good behavior. It is what is left when craving is extinguished — the natural state that was always there underneath.

Confucius (551-479 BCE, China) saw his own time — the Warring States period — as a society that had lost its way. His prescription was *li* (ritual propriety): structured practices that reinforce right relationship. His “rectification of names” is an argument against HILO: if a ruler does not rule, they are not a ruler, regardless of what they call themselves. The noble person (*junzi*) “is calm and at ease; the small person is always anxious and full of concern.” Fear Of Missing Out (FOMO) vs. Joy Of Missing Out (JOMO) rendered as character types.

Jesus (30 CE, Galilee) told his followers to “consider the lilies of the field, they neither toil nor spin” — pure Joy Of Missing Out (JOMO). The kingdom of heaven is within you — accessible not by achieving but by *remembering what you already are*. Turn the other cheek — do not enter the FAFO cycle. Love your neighbor as yourself — Yes In My Back Yard (YIMBY) at the spiritual level.

The Stoics (Zeno, Epictetus, Marcus Aurelius) developed the dichotomy of control: some things are up to you, most are not. Suffering comes from wanting what is not up to you. They embodied Pay Attention, Find Out (PAFO) — learning through reason and observation rather than through painful experience and collision. *Amor fati* (love of fate) is the ultimate YIMBY — not just accepting reality but loving it exactly as it is. Marcus Aurelius: “The universe is change; life is opinion.”

Zera Yacob (1599-1692, Ethiopia) independently arrived at a natural theology based on reason alone, arguing that the Creator made an orderly universe that rewards truthfulness. He diagnosed History Is the Loudest Opinion (HILO) directly: “People are led astray by the authority of their forefathers. They believe what they are told without examination.”

Aquinas (13th century, Europe) systematized natural law: there is a deep structure to reality that is good, and human laws are only just insofar as they align with it. Truth is not what the powerful say it is — it is built into existence. History Is the Truth of What Happened (HITW) as theology.

All of them diagnosed the same disease: the forgetting of the **Second Path** and the consequent cascade into comparison, territoriality, collision, and narrative distortion. All of them prescribed the same cure: practice, attention, remembering, and the cultivation of contentment with what is.

3.6 Meso-Level Systems

The same cascade appears in systems too small to be civilizational but too large to be individual.

Startups. Year 1: everyone sleeps on couches, shares everything, no titles, no politics. Second path. Year 3: Series A hires bring FOMO (“Why don’t we have a gym like Google?”). Title inflation. Year 5: NIMBY — departments hoard headcount, teams stop sharing code. Year 8: FAFO — product bloat, toxic culture, layoffs. Year 10: HILO — the C-suite rewrites the origin story; within a decade nobody remembers what the company originally made.

Marriages. Year 1: unconditional generosity, assuming best intent, pure JOMO. Years 3-7: FOMO creeps in (“Steve’s wife doesn’t make him do that”). Years 5-15: NIMBY solidifies (“that’s your chore,” “my money”). The crisis: FAFO — betrayal, explosion, something that cannot be taken back. Aftermath: HILO — both partners rewrite the history to make themselves the victim. The marriage becomes two competing narratives, and the truth of what happened is lost.

Scientific revolutions (Thomas Kuhn’s structure). Normal science: **Second Path** — curiosity, shared rules, incremental progress. Anomalies accumulate; the establishment defends the paradigm (NIMBY). Crisis: FAFO — the debate becomes personal and political, not empirical. Paradigm shift: the old guard dies, the new model wins, and the textbooks are rewritten to make the old paradigm look obviously wrong. Kuhn called this “the rewriting of history” explicitly.

4. The Fermi Paradox: Why the Sky Is Silent

The universality of this cascade suggests a disturbing answer to one of science’s deepest questions.

The Drake Equation estimates the number of detectable civilizations in the galaxy as the product of several factors: the rate of star formation, the fraction of stars with planets, the fraction of planets that could support life, the fraction where life appears, the fraction where intelligence evolves, the fraction that develop technology, and — critically — the length of time such a civilization remains detectable.

The first six terms are all optimistic. Modern astronomy has confirmed most stars have planets, habitable zones are common, and life appeared on Earth within a few hundred million years of the planet’s formation. Intelligence has emerged at least once. Technology has emerged at least once.

The huge unknown is the last term: L , the lifespan of a technological civilization.

The standard answer to the Fermi Paradox — “Where is everybody?” — has been a version of the Great Filter: something prevents civilizations from reaching interstellar capability. The usual candidates are nuclear war, resource depletion, asteroid impacts, or ecological collapse.

The argument of this essay is that the filter is more fundamental. It is not an external event. It is the internal cascade described above. Any civilization that reaches technology will inevitably encounter the FOMO/NIMBY/FAFO/HILO cycle. The question is whether the cycle can be survived.

The **Second Path** (coherence, long-term thinking, collective alignment) is the only state from which a multi-century project like interstellar colonization can be sustained. But the **Second Path** requires continuous maintenance. The moment a civilization forgets to maintain it — the moment energy flows into comparison and territoriality rather than cooperation — the cascade begins. And the cascade moves faster than a civilization can build generation ships.

The galaxy may not be empty. It may be filled with ruins — civilizations that reached radio technology, experienced the cascade, and collapsed before they could cross space. The ones that *did* cross space would be the statistical outliers: the rare civilizations that somehow maintained the **Second Path** long enough to escape their home system.

This also explains why we have not detected them. A civilization in the **Second Path** does not shout. It does not flood the galaxy with signals the way a teenager floods social media. It is quiet because it is content. And a civilization in the FOMO-to-FAFO cascade is listening to its own internal noise, not broadcasting to the stars.

The silence of the sky is not evidence of absence. It is evidence of the same forgetting, playing out at the same scale, everywhere.

5. Stripping External Explanations

The power of this framework depends on what it does *not* invoke.

No male/female duality. The **Second Path** and **First Path** are not opposing forces that must be balanced in the manner of yin and yang. They are not gendered. They are not complementary principles that together make a whole. They are consecutive states of a single system: coherence and its decay. The dualistic framing of Western and Eastern thought has often obscured this by presenting balance as the goal. Balance is not the goal. *Maintaining coherence is the goal.* Balance is what coherence looks like from the outside.

No random asteroid events. The standard story of the dinosaur extinction is: everything was fine, then a rock fell from the sky, catastrophe. This essay argues that the real story is the forgetting that made the system brittle over millions of years. The asteroid was punctuation. Internal dynamics — overspecialization, reduced genetic diversity, ecosystem simplification, resource exhaustion — had already set the collapse in motion. The asteroid just happened to be the trigger that made the collapse visible. In systems that do not encounter an asteroid, the internal cascade reaches the same endpoint, just more slowly.

No continental drift. Plate tectonics is offered as an explanation for everything from ice ages to species distribution to mass extinctions. But the pattern described here operates *within* the biosphere regardless of the arrangement of landmasses. The system's internal coherence is the variable, not the configuration of the crust.

The framework is strongest when it has the fewest external dependencies. The cascade recurs because it is internal to complex systems, not because of environmental circumstances. If the environment changes, the cascade changes speed but not direction. A system that remembers its coherence survives external shocks. A system that has forgotten falls to shocks that a coherent system would barely notice.

6. Climate Change: The Current Test Case

Climate change is the most literal application of this framework because the natural system itself acts as the enforcer.

The Holocene — 12,000 years of stable temperature, CO₂, and sea levels — is the **Second Path** of the planetary system. It was the equilibrium that made civilization possible. It required no human maintenance because natural systems — the carbon cycle, ocean currents, forest biomes, atmospheric chemistry — maintained it automatically.

The industrial revolution initiated the FOMO phase. Coal was adopted not because it was sustainable but because it gave England an advantage over competitors. Every nation since has repeated the calculation: grow now, deal with consequences later.

The NIMBY phase is visible in the Paris Agreement's structure: every nation wants the global benefit of climate action while protecting local fossil fuel interests. "Renewables are great — just not in my county." Carbon offsets that allow continued emissions while claiming progress.

The FAFO phase is unfolding in real time. Heatwaves, fires, floods, crop failures, hurricanes, ecosystem collapse events — each by itself dismissed as an outlier, but the accumulated weight is unmistakable. The system does not negotiate.

The HILO phase is in full swing. Fossil fuel companies that knew in the 1970s that their product caused warming now present themselves as energy companies leading the transition. Carbon capture is promoted as a solution despite not existing at scale. Offsets are traded that represent no actual sequestration. The narrative is being rewritten in real time.

The distinction from other case studies is crucial: climate is not *a* system among many. It is the *substrate* that all other human systems sit on. When it tips, there is no successor environment to write the history. HILO ends when there are no readers.

7. Implications

If this framework is even approximately correct, it carries consequences that are difficult to accept.

The Second Path is not a stable equilibrium. It is the default state of a newly formed system, but it requires continuous maintenance. There is no permanent enlightenment, no utopia, no end of history. Every coherent system will eventually forget — faster if it grows large, faster if it becomes complacent, faster if it believes the work of maintenance is complete.

External shocks are never the real cause of collapse. They are triggers that reveal an internal state already degraded. This means that preparing for external threats — asteroid defense, military deterrence, backup systems — is necessary but insufficient. The real protection is internal coherence. A coherent system survives shocks. A brittle system blames them.

The cascade accelerates. Each stage feeds the next. FOMO creates NIMBY. NIMBY guarantees FAFO. FAFO enables HILO. The only intervention point is early — before comparison becomes territoriality. Once territoriality is entrenched, collision is inevitable, and collision requires the energy of the **Second Path** to survive.

The cure is remembering — and practice.

Every philosopher who diagnosed this disease prescribed the same treatment:

- Buddha: daily meditation, mindfulness, letting go
- Confucius: ritual practice, right relationship, calling things by their true names
- Jesus: love of neighbor, non-resistance, considering the lilies
- Stoics: daily reflection, dichotomy of control, *amor fati*
- Aquino: aligning human law with natural law through reason
- Zera Yacob: rejecting inherited authority, examining reality with your own reason

These are not doctrines to believe. They are *practices to do*. The **Second Path** is not a concept that can be understood intellectually. It is a state that must be maintained actively, moment by moment, generation by generation. The moment practice stops, forgetting begins.

But practice alone is not enough, because the forgetting is not merely a failure of will — it has a psychological mechanism. Research from Harvard Business School shows that people systematically filter out negative information, especially when acting on it would require changing their behavior. Psychologists call this *normalcy bias*: the deep-seated tendency to believe that because something bad has not happened recently, it cannot happen soon. At an individual level this is merely self-deception. At a civilizational level it is catastrophic — entire institutions built on past solutions defend those solutions long after the problems have changed. The cascade does not just proceed *despite* knowledge of it. It proceeds *because* the knowledge is structurally filtered out before it can produce action.

This argues for a second kind of intervention alongside individual practice: institutional design. The post-war European Union was built not on the hope that nations would *remember* the costs of war, but on a structure that made war between members economically impossible. The institutional answer to Santayana’s warning is not to memorize more history but to build systems that do not require memory to function — to engineer the structural incentives so that the self-destructive choice is harder and the adaptive choice is easier. Practice works on the individual. Architecture works on the system. Both are required, because the forgetting operates at both scales.

8. Glossary

A glossary of scientific terms and foreign words appears below for readers who encounter unfamiliar terms. All definitions are in plain language.

8.1 The Acronym Tree

THE SECOND PATH (coherence — the default state before forgetting)

Term	Definition
JOMO	Joy Of Missing Out — contentment with what is; the stable state before comparison begins
YIMBY	Yes In My Back Yard — acceptance of tradeoffs; willingness to share costs and benefits
PAFO	Pay Attention, Find Out — learning by observation rather than painful experience
	History Is the Truth of What

HITW	Happened — commitment to accuracy over narrative
Second Path	The coherent default state; parts align, energy flows, contentment and truth prevail naturally
Coherence	The quality of a system that knows itself and maintains its own structure without external enforcement

THE FIRST PATH (decay — what happens when the Second Path is forgotten)

Term	Definition
FOMO	Fear Of Missing Out — comparison-driven desire for what others have; the first stage of the cascade
NIMBY	Not In My Back Yard — demanding benefits while refusing costs; the territorial stage
FAFO	Fuck Around, Find Out — the unavoidable collision when accumulated contradictions meet reality
HILO	History Is the Loudest Opinion — the rewriting of the record by narrative dominance rather than accuracy
First Path	The decayed state that follows forgetting; comparison, territoriality, collision, and narrative distortion dominate

8.2 Scientific Terms

Term	Definition
Coherence	A state where all parts of a system are aligned with each other and behave as a single, predictable whole (see also Decoherence , Second Path)
Decoherence	The process by which a quantum system loses its superposition through interaction with its environment; in this essay, the physical analog of forgetting at

	every scale
Dualism	The belief that reality is composed of two fundamental and opposing principles (mind/matter, good/evil, order/chaos); this essay explicitly rejects dualism in favor of a single-path-and-its-decay model
Entanglement	A quantum connection between particles where measuring one instantly determines the state of the other, regardless of distance
Entropy	The tendency of all systems to move from order toward disorder over time if no energy is added to maintain them
Homeostasis	A system's ability to maintain stable internal conditions despite external changes; the biological version of coherence maintenance
Quantum state	A description of a particle as a cloud of possibilities — all the states it could be in before interacting with its environment (see also Superposition)
Classical state	A single definite outcome that a quantum system settles into once it interacts with its environment through decoherence
Quantum wavefunction	The mathematical description of all possible states a quantum system could occupy and their probabilities
Specialization	In evolution, the process by which a species adapts to a narrow range of conditions, trading overall adaptability for efficiency in a specific niche
Substrate	The underlying layer or medium that supports the system above it; in this essay, the climate is described as the substrate civilization sits on
Superposition	A quantum state where a particle exists in multiple configurations at once until it interacts with its environment

8.3 Foreign Words & Phrases

Note: This essay refers to figures and concepts from major religious and philosophical traditions — Buddhism, Christianity, Confucianism, Stoicism, and others — as narrative examples of a recurring human insight. These traditions are matters of living faith and practice for billions of people. The essay does not intend to flatten them into intellectual props or to treat them flippantly. It uses them because they independently arrived at the same diagnosis of a recurring human problem, which lends weight to the pattern described here. The reader is invited to engage with these references as evidence of a convergent insight, not as a dismissal of the faith or practice they belong to.

All foreign terms are italicized on first use in the essay. The original language and a plain-language translation are given below.

Term	Language	Translation / Meaning
<i>amor fati</i>	Latin	Love of fate — embracing whatever happens as necessary and good (Stoicism)
<i>junzi</i>	Chinese	The noble person — a person of virtue and integrity in Confucian philosophy
<i>li</i>	Chinese	Ritual propriety — the structured practices that maintain right relationship in Confucian philosophy
<i>mos maiorum</i>	Latin	“The way of the ancestors” — unwritten Roman norms of civic virtue and tradition
<i>pachakuti</i>	Quechua	A world-overturning — the violent reset at the end of an Andean world-age
<i>tanha</i>	Pali	Craving, thirst — the desire for things to be other than they are; the root of all suffering in Buddhism
		The four-age Hindu model of civilizational decline: <i>Satya Yuga</i>

<i>Yuga cycle</i>	Sanskrit	(truth, contentment), <i>Treta Yuga</i> (sacrifice, ritual), <i>Dvapara Yuga</i> (disease, war), and <i>Kali Yuga</i> (greed, short lives, narrative chaos)
-------------------	----------	--

9. References

Though this essay is an original synthesis, the ideas it synthesizes draw on a wide range of sources, acknowledged here.

Approach: The Universal Arc

- Schrödinger, E. (1944). *What Is Life?* — The earliest clear articulation that life resists entropy through continuous maintenance of internal order.
- Prigogine, I. & Stengers, I. (1984). *Order Out of Chaos*. — Dissipative structures and far-from-equilibrium thermodynamics.
- Kuhn, T. (1962). *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*. — The four-stage pattern of normal science, crisis, revolution, and rewriting of history.

On Civilizational Cycles

- The Vedas and Puranas (anonymous, c. 1500-500 BCE) — The Yuga cycle descriptions.
- Guaman Poma de Ayala, F. (c. 1615). *El Primer Nueva Corónica y Buen Gobierno*. — Primary Andean source on the concept of Pachakuti and world ages.

On the Diagnosis in Philosophy

- The Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (Buddha's first sermon, c. 528 BCE) — The Four Noble Truths, identifying craving (tanha) as the root of suffering.
- The Analects of Confucius (c. 475-221 BCE) — The rectification of names, li, and the junzi.
- The Gospel of Matthew (c. 70-110 CE) — The Sermon on the Mount, especially the lilies of the field.
- Aurelius, M. (c. 170-180 CE). *Meditations*. — The core Stoic texts on the dichotomy of control.
- Epictetus (c. 108 CE). *Discourses*. — Enchiridion, the manual on distinguishing what is and is not up to us.
- Yacob, Z. (1667). *Hatāta* ("The Inquiry"). — Natural theology through reason alone, critique of inherited authority.
- Aquinas, T. (1274). *Summa Theologica*. — Natural law, the cardinal virtues, and the relationship between grace and nature.

On Social and Technological Collapse

- Gibbon, E. (1776-1789). *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman*

Empire. — The classic account of internal decay preceding external collapse.

- Tainter, J. (1988). *The Collapse of Complex Societies*. — The diminishing marginal returns of complexity as a driver of collapse.
- Turchin, P. (2012). “Dynamics of Political Instability in the United States, 1780-2010.” *Journal of Peace Research*. — Cliodynamic modeling and the prediction of the 2020 instability peak using elite overproduction theory.
- Samvero (2026). “The Pattern Behind Every Major Civilization Collapse.” *YouTube*. — A convergent synthesis of Tainter, Turchin, and Toynbee; the v1.1 additions to this essay (Maya deforestation case study, cliodynamics, normalcy bias, and institutional design) were prompted by this video.
- Diamond, J. (2005). *Collapse*. — Case studies of societies that failed due to resource mismanagement.
- Slotine, J.J. & Lohmiller, W. (1998). “Contraction Analysis of Nonlinear Systems.” — The mathematical framework for understanding how systems lose stability.

On Cognitive Biases and Structural Forgetting

- Sharot, T. (2011). “The Optimism Bias.” *Current Biology*. — On the systematic filtering of negative information, the psychological mechanism that makes knowledge alone insufficient to prevent the cascade.
- Kahneman, D. (2011). *Thinking, Fast and Slow*. — Cognitive biases including normalcy bias and the systematic underestimation of tail risks.

On the Fermi Paradox and the Great Filter

- Drake, F. (1961). The Drake Equation formalization.
- Hart, M. (1975). “An Explanation for the Absence of Extraterrestrials on Earth.” — Early formulation of the Great Filter argument.
- Ćirković, M. (2008). “Against the Empire.” — Argues that the silence of the sky may be evidence of a universal filter related to the internal dynamics of civilizations.

On Climate and Ecological Collapse

- IPCC Reports (1990-2025). — The accumulating evidence on the current cascade.
- Lenton, T. et al. (2008). “Tipping Elements in the Earth’s Climate System.” — The science of critical thresholds in planetary systems.
- Kolbert, E. (2014). *The Sixth Extinction*. — The current mass extinction event driven by the forgetting of planetary coherence.
- Cook, B. et al. (2012). “Deforestation-Induced Climate Change and the Classic Maya Collapse.” *Journal of Geophysical Research*. — Satellite and paleoclimate evidence linking Maya deforestation to warm/dry conditions and the terminal collapse.
- Kennett, D. et al. (2012). “Development and Disintegration of Maya Political Systems in Response to Climate Change.” *Science*. — Lake

sediment and cave deposit records confirming severe multi-decadal droughts during the terminal Classic period.

The Quantum Analog

- Zurek, W. (2003). “Decoherence, Einselection, and the Quantum Origins of the Classical.” — The definitive modern treatment of decoherence as the transition from quantum to classical, the physical basis for the universal cascade.

What You Can Do With This

If this framework resonated with you, take it. Argue with it. Test it against your own experience. Share it with someone who needs to see it.

The pattern only changes if enough people see it — and seeing it is the first step. The next time you feel FOMO rising, you might notice it before it becomes territoriality. The next time you hear someone rewriting history to suit their narrative, you might recognize HILO in real time. The next time you face a collision, you might survive it instead of blaming the universe.

The **Second Path** — coherence, contentment, truthfulness, cooperation — is not a utopia to be built. It is a practice to be maintained, moment by moment, generation by generation. It requires no new technology, no political revolution, no charismatic leader. It only requires enough of us to *remember* what we already know, and to act on it before the forgetting takes hold again.

We build a civilization capable of reaching the stars one remembering at a time.

Acknowledgments

The author is solely responsible for the content. The four-letter acronym system (FOMO/NIMBY/FAFO/HILO and JOMO/YIMBY/PAFO/HITW) emerged from extended discussion with the author’s collaborator, who wishes to remain unnamed but whose contribution to the framework is foundational.

This essay is released under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0). Share freely, attribute the source.